Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

Wendell Brunious

Wendell Brunious' trumpet and flugelhorn are a welcome addition to many festivals around the country. Wendell grew up playing Dixieland in his home town of New Orleans and he is comfortable in a variety of jazz settings, including the college classroom. In the first part of the interview, Wendell and his friend trombonist Dan Barrett share a conversation.

Wendell was interviewed at the Los Angeles Classic Jazz Festival on September 3, 1995 by Michael Woods. Monk Rowe was also present for the interview.

DB: Well I guess we're on camera. My name is Dan Barrett and I'm privileged and honored to introduce a very good friend of mine and a terrific trumpet player from New Orleans, Mr. Wendell Brunious.

WB: Thank you, Daniel.

DB: You're welcome.

WB: I was sitting there in admiration of your comments, especially about Louis Armstrong, who, without him, I really don't know what position jazz would be — I don't know if there would even be jazz actually.

DB: Well I know you'll agree it's kind of sad that even accomplished, even many accomplished jazz musicians don't fully understand what Louis did for the music you know. And they give him a lot of lip service and say oh Pops, oh yeah, Satchmo, yeah Louis, yeah, right. And I don't think that many of them have actually checked out those records.

WB: I agree with you.

DB: But if you think about it, like for instance when Louis was with Fletcher Henderson's band in the early 20s, and he turned everybody around just like Charlie Parker did later. And everybody wanted to be like Louis Armstrong. And I read, you probably read this, like Rex Stewart went out and got a pair of clunky shoes like Louis used to wear. And Rex said, "Yeah I used to try to walk like him and dress like him and play like him and I wanted to be him."

WB: They tell me when Louis went to Chicago he had like a box back coat, which had gone out of style, and everybody started wearing box back coats. I probably would have done it myself when you think about it.

DB: But that band changed after Louis was in it, the Henderson band. All of a sudden, I mean you hear the records before he came into the band and if it was swinging, it wasn't swinging in the way it was after Louis was there.

WB: I agree with you.

DB: And then the whole big band era. See people don't, they don't give Louis credit. He kind of founded the Swing Era. Because Fletcher started writing those arrangements. We were talking about Benny Goodman earlier. And Fletcher Henderson started writing arrangements and really all he was doing, not to diminish what he was doing, but what Fletcher would do that made those arrangements so great, is he was writing, phrasing, like Louis would play. They were pop tunes from the day, but Fletcher Henderson would sit there and imagine, now how would Louis play this phrase. So he'd write for five brass.

WB: That's a strong impact on everything.

DB: Well that's enough about him. Let's talk about you.

WB: I just want to say this. I heard a professor one time, and he said, "Oh, yeah, Louis Armstrong. The guy would sometimes play a whole solo with one note." Oh yeah? And I mean it's horrible to hear something like that because this is a guy that's teaching young people hopefully to play jazz. And if you don't teach someone to respect and investigate Louis Armstrong, I don't think you're teaching them the right thing. Because he was a force to be reckoned with, to say the very least.

DB: My brother-in-law, I don't think you've met him, Ryan Shaw is his name. He's a real good trumpet player from the west coast. A few years ago I was at his house and he had this, well it was a textbook and it was a real dry textbook. I can't remember the exact title, but it was something like Principles of Brass Playing in the Modern Orchestra. And it was talking about symphonic brass playing. And I said, "What should I see about this," because it looked pretty boring, a big textbook. He said, "Well look up, I think it's page 288. I opened it up and the heading was "Vibrato." And in very formal language, by a professor or something, it said something about the use of vibrato was shunned in symphonic works, and it was forbidden to use vibrato until the middle to late 1930s. And at that time, and there it is in print, it said there was a trumpet player from New Orleans, Louis Armstrong, who exerted such an overwhelming influence on brass players that the judicious use of vibrato is today accepted, at the composer's discretion, or at the conductor's discretion. I said wow, you know, so we're not just talking about jazz, we're talking about brass playing, and people don't understand that Louis was — well I've heard this about Louis, have you heard this? Oh, yeah, he couldn't read too well. You know, come on. He was sight reading those things? Studio dates every day? Sight singing too, not sight playing. Tune he never saw. Sight singing. And he was on a first name basis with the principal trumpet players of the orchestras around the country. Well that's enough about Louis Armstrong.

WB: Not enough can be said about Louis Armstrong, let's face it. My daughter has a little friend in New Orleans and the little friend's babysitter, once I went to pick them up to

take them for a cool drink or something. And the lady gets in the car and she says, "You're a jazz musician, right?" I say, "Yeah." She says, "You know my cousin played trumpet." I say, "Really, who is it?" She says, "Louis Armstrong." Armstrong, man, I got the shakes man.

DB: My cousin played trumpet, oh that's nice.

WB: You know, you'd think Joe Smooth or somebody you know. Louis Armstrong. That may be enough about Louis even though not enough can be said.

DB: I just want to ask you did you ever hear him in person?

WB: No. I saw him one time but I never really heard him in person.

DB: Yeah, I never did either. I've had real vivid dreams about him.

WB: I'll bet.

DB: Kind of funny, like hearing him play in these dreams. And he talked to me. Oh it was really weird. And he did it with Jon Kellso too, the young trumpet player in New York. Kellso had a similar dream. Like it makes me cry to think about it. He said he was sitting on a park bench and he saw Louis sitting on this other park bench, and then Louis got up in this dream and walked over the just sat down by him and took his hand and just kind of patted his hand. Like, you know, don't worry about a thing, everything's going to be all right. Crazy. Weird.

WB: That's got to be like the best dream you could have I think. When I was a little kid, it was about 1963 or something like that, Louis Armstrong came to New Orleans. And this big brass band like George Lewis and Punch Miller and my dad and everybody went out there to meet Louis. And my dad told my brother and I said, "Look, get some clothes on, I'm going to take you someplace" you know and we were wondering where we were going. He said, "I'm going to take you see Louis Armstrong." I really didn't think I would see Louis Armstrong. But we went to the airport and when Louis stepped out of the plane, man that band hit — boom. And a smile came over Louis Armstrong's face. He had a white baseball cap on and it was just something I could never forget. And he rubbed me on the head like that. "Hey Pops." That was one of the greatest moments of my life.

DB: I'll bet.

WB: I mean we keep saying this enough about Louis Armstrong, but we keep going.

DB: Well if anything, I hope all this talk, whoever might see this, if they haven't examined those records, and it doesn't matter, it doesn't matter what record, if he's on it, it's going to be great.

WB: That's right.

DB: It doesn't matter whether it's the 20s or the 30s or 40s or 50s or 60s.

WB: And what timing man. That's one thing that you could get from Louis Armstrong, listening to him. The timing. Because I mean, you know, he had it. He created it basically. But anyway. What else do you talk about after Louis Armstrong? Louis Armstrong is God I guess. Also, when you were saying with the young players, when he was asking about trying to get them, what would you advise them about learning to play jazz, and you made such a strong statement about learning melodies. Because and you even said this about when you play a solo, it's just another melody. That's all it is. A melody, by my definition — and Webster didn't have anything to do with this one — but I thought it was kind of think of it as a series of notes that tie some changes together. And that's basically what a solo is.

DB: That's right.

WB: So I mean to learn melodies, which I don't think we accentuate upon them enough in the schools. I mean my dad had recorded a record with Paul Barbarin in the 1950s and one of the cuts on there was "Bourbon Street Parade" which Paul Barbarin wrote. And what my dad used to do was he'd tell us, "I'm going out for a while, and I want you to learn like Bob Thomas' solo on 'Bourbon Street Parade.'" And as a result of that I can hum that solo right now, you know? That had that kind of impact on me. And you know I mean I'm not a real older style player, in fact still, it's in me.

DB: You don't think so, huh?

WB: Well I mean, but it's like you know that's really maturing type of tactics and things to do that help you to mature faster. I think so.

DB: I do too. I didn't know anything about improvising when I first heard these jazz records. I didn't know they were making it up out of their heads. I just liked the music, you know. And then I remember hearing a Bix Beiderbecke record and reading all the critics or the writers you know they say the same thing. I think one guy reads something and then he recycles it you know. But everything I read about Bix Beiderbecke, they said he was fond of ninths and thirteenths. I thought oh well, that's nice. And then the next writer would say oh he likes ninths and thirteenths. And then I heard some record, I think it was "Somebody Stole My Gal," and Bix plays this real nice phrase, and he went down to this kind of unusual note that rubbed up against the root of the chord. And I thought gee that sounds real strange but it sounds real good and real right. And then finally I was, you know, the light came on that I should start playing a little more piano or trying to find out about the keyboard, which is some other advice we could give to students. You know even if you haven't studied piano formally, just get acquainted with the keyboard so you can see chords and learn about changes. And I went over to the keyboard and I finally found out what chord that was, and then I realized it was like an E flat seventh, and Bix had gone down to an F. And I thought well that's one, two, three, four, five, six, seven,

eight, nine. Oh, that's a ninth. Oh that's a ninth. Oh, yeah. You know, light — 20 watt light bulb. Oh that's what a ninth is. And I went nine, ten, eleven, twelve, thirteen, oh, that's a thirteenth. Oh, yeah, I've heard him do that. And then of course, as I mentioned, when I first heard Charlie Parker and I go back to my Dixieland band and try and play like Charlie Parker. Well then every solo I played, I went immediately for the ninth. Ninth, ninth, ninth — Banjo players, "Aw, Dan."

MR: I don't want to rush you here, but we want to get you to your gig on time.

DB: Oh, the heck with it. We'll just stay here, send out for pizza. Do you have anything to tell the camera?

WB: Well I've got so much respect for Dan Barrett that I would tend to listen to you, Dan.

DB: Thank you. You know the feeling is mutual, and it has been a long time.

WB: Thank you man.

DB: Nice to have this little chat. We should do this more often. Maybe we'll get our own talk show.

WB: Hey, everybody's got 'em.

[pause]

MW: We are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. And we have with us today a trumpet virtuoso from New Orleans, Wendell Brunious.

WB: How you doing?

MW: Great. Give us some of the color of New Orleans. How and why is New Orleans such a special city for this music?

WB: Well, that's a big question. That's really a big question. New Orleans is pretty much a melting pot. I mean the whole, the people of New Orleans, you know the Creole people along with the African people along with the real French people and the South American people and Asians that came there, I mean it. New Orleans is basically an island. So when you came there, you were pretty stuck there, you know what I mean? So I mean not much penetrated New Orleans and it allowed what was there to like generate into what it is, which a lot of people respect and some people don't. But the music that came out of New Orleans was music from all of those influences, the work song, and then the Latin beat and the French military music, and all of that stuff came to be New Orleans music. And a friend of mine said this: most of the jazz you hear today owes something to Congo Square, which I don't know if you know what Congo Square is.

MW: I know something of it but I want to get your opinion on it. Tell us about Congo Square.

WB: Well I don't actually know that much about it. But it was kind of like where, kind of slaves and people of color or whatever you want to call them kind of celebrated their rituals and parties or jazz festivals or whatever they wanted to call it in that day you know? And that's where a lot of that stuff was developed. And it was not too influenced

by anything else but what was in New Orleans, because New Orleans was pretty isolated. That's the way I see it. You read these books and you know, people go off to the moon and different things, and you know everyone's got a story. But that's the way I see it. I mean I'm a fourth generation New Orleanean so I feel pretty good about saying that. Because I had an old uncle who played with Buddy Bolden, and so I'm a fourth generation musician also. And New Orleans is just a really special place in the world. I really mean that. It's just such a great place.

MW: And it isn't just the people. For instance, the whole sensational palette is enlivened. The food.

WB: Yeah, definitely. The food is the best. I can actually say that. A lot of cooks and chefs nowadays, as soon as they say something Cajun or Creole, that means add pepper to it and you can't taste it. That is not right. That is not the way we do it there. We have spicy food, but not hot spicy. It's spiced with like three different kinds of bell pepper, shallots, red onion, yellow onion, some pepper, quite naturally hot pepper, but not this overwhelming thing, you know, this burnt stuff they're selling and passing off as New Orleans food. No, no, no.

MW: Something else, the brass bands were important as a vehicle for the development of this music. Talk to us about particularly the African-American tradition of the burial bands.

WB: Well it's a belief in New Orleans that I mean when you die, it's not like the end then. So it's kind of like a party that we give the guy a sendoff into his next thing, whatever that is. I mean whatever —

MW: His next gig.

WB: Yeah, his next gig. I like the way you said that, next gig. So like on the way we give respect and all of those kinds of things to the body on the way to the cemetery. We play dirges and quite naturally the family is sad, people who knew this person is sad, and when we get to the cemetery, we play a nice slow hymn, some kind of hymn, "What a Friend We Have in Jesus," or "Goodbye Charlie" or whatever it's going to be. And then we immediately turn around and start the celebration. Because this guy has gone on somewhere else now. And I think that's a really great way of looking at it, rather than dwelling upon, oh man, my brother's dead or whoever it is. The family doesn't take part usually in the celebration, quite naturally. But the rest of the people just kind of turn him loose and set him free to do whatever's next.

MW: And the music is a large part of that. It helps them do that.

WB: Oh, yeah. So we hit up one of those real lively songs with a bass drum. We're kind of losing that in New Orleans. Because that was a very, very respectful tradition at one time. But then all of a sudden it got to be less and less organized. Then you started getting a lot of people who wanted to participate, which is nice, it's nice people want to participate in

it, but as they participate, the real tradition is being destroyed, or like diluted. And then, all of a sudden like these kid bands started coming out, in tee shirts and jeans. Like whenever we had a funeral parade, everyone was dressed in a black or dark suit, white shirt and tie. Black hat, you know. That's the way that tradition went. But now, everybody's got the baseball cap backwards, and you know and I mean the tradition is in serious threat there. Now and then we have a real, traditional New Orleans funeral. But it's because these people are responding more to these young kid's bands, which is high energy, but they don't have the proper respect for the tradition or for the purpose of the funeral parade itself. You know, and not to mention, they don't really know those hymns. Because they don't respect that kind of music. And I mean it's just like, you know, this is a fast world now. Everything is going really, really fast. So —

MW: In other words, continuity and change have to be balanced.

WB: Yes. They have to be. That's a great way of putting that. They have to be balanced. And if they're not balanced, we're going to destroy that tradition, which is in a big threat now. We just buried an old guy from the Preservation Hall, Mr. Percy Humphrey. And you know we tried to keep it as a traditional jazz funeral. But it was, a lot of people started coming in there, some lady playing the flute with tights and you know, a leotard and all this kind of crazy stuff you know. I mean she's got a right to express herself. But that's not part of that thing. And we didn't walk too far. The weather was really bad. And everyone, the crowd was like getting into the band, getting between the band and you can't play that way, man. Because is doesn't take but one elbow, you know, on the end of your horn, to knock your teeth out, and that's the end. Because it's just the end that's it. So you have to be very careful with stuff like that. And if they don't respect the band, you know, or the tradition, it's going to be destroyed. And a lot of guys were like hardly playing because so many people were walking in and out of the band.

MW: This makes a case for jazz education going beyond the classroom, into what we call etiquette. Concert etiquette. But I want to say this about yourself, and then talk a little bit. I see you as being an important person, being a relatively young man, from New Orleans, restoring some of the respect of the music and the tradition. Do you see — where do you see yourself?

WB: Well I don't feel I am respected enough. Like I don't think people look at me as real important. I really don't. Because I don't know, I'm not one of these real ultra contemporary neo jazz guys. You know what I mean? I'm very much a pretty conservative musician. You know my dad always was a great musician, wrote for Billy Eckstine, Cab Calloway, Jay McShann, Walter Fats Pichon, and all these real bands. You know? And he just taught us to do what was right. Just follow your heart. Do what's right man. And a lot of times that gets, you know, not recognized in the world as we know it

now. I teach at the University of New Orleans. And the response I get from a lot of these kids is like, oh yeah, well you're playing old time, or something like that. I mean I'm pretty much a New Orleans and kind of more like a Bebop trumpet player. Which I mean Bebop had the feeling, you know still had the feeling. With all of these modes like Dan was explaining, man, you know I don't feel that. You know it's very, very like intellectual. Really like, wow man, that guy must really know some really high-powered stuff, you know, and all of this stuff that comes from Vienna and all of this kind of stuff. You understand what I'm saying. Not to put that down, but I think jazz is like heartfelt. You know that's art from the heart, not from the brain. But this wave that's happened, it's so big we can't do anything about it. So that's why I say I don't feel like really respected or important in that way. Because those kids that I teach and that I encounter all around the country, especially in America, their first thing is I want to be famous. And like is that why you're playing the horn to be famous man? Don't you have something to say?

MW: This brings up another question to put on the floor and then you kind of jump in on that is the heart of the music, I've always felt that anything that you fall in love with, it will reveal its secrets to you.

WB: I agree with that. I couldn't agree with you more. And this is like, I don't know, it's just to comment upon that without seeming like you're taking a shot at someone, but you know it's not that easy. We have to get these guys to teach these kids more about melody and you know, just like Dan said, you know someone may give you ten dollars to play "'Round Midnight" or something like that, but they'll never give you twenty dollars and say hey man, can you plan a locrian scale, you know, here's twenty-five bucks or something like that. And it just seems like jazz is going away from the heart and more to the head, and I don't like that movement, I really don't. I mean that's just me, and who am I in the whole world? But I think we have to get back to playing melodies. Get back to drummers playing real time. You know all this [scats] and all this stuff, great, after the time is established, you know? And all of these crazy scales and way out stuff guys are playing, great. After the melody has been established. Most of these tunes, you know, hardly have any melody at all man. [Scats] Then some F locrian scale [scats] and the cats are gone man. And you're like, hold up man, maybe I'm missing something here. Maybe I missed it. But I think we have to get back to beautiful melodies, and it just may be the era that we're living in. Because so many beautiful songs came, like World War I, all of those beautiful songs that came in the teens and the twenties and after World War II, all of these beautiful songs that came out when people were missing, you know, your loved one is away and people still were really true in their hearts back then. I'm not too sure about that anymore. But a lot of that beautiful stuff that came out of that was the end result of those like, you know, lovers missing each other.

MW: So in other words a song, a real song, doesn't just come because you know the notes and the scales and you can play chord X. Songs come from experience. Talk to us about real experience.

WB: Well experience and emotion. Emotion is one of the main like parts of playing a song. Especially a ballad. You have to really know the words basically to the ballad. And the words, I try to make that come out of the end of the horn. One of my favorite records, you know when Dan was saying about Louis Armstrong, he's number one. Whoever doesn't think Louis Armstrong is number one has the wrong idea. I'm very convinced of that. Because without Louis Armstrong, I don't know where jazz would be. I don't know, I really don't know what could have happened without Louis Armstrong. But I mean you could hear the words come out of Louis Armstrong's horn. When you hear Charlie Parker with strings, you hear words coming out of an alto. Clifford Brown with strings, you hear words coming out of the end of the horn. And you know that's why I think it's so important to know the words of a song. When you say [sings] "embrace me," there's an emotion there, you know that happens. And I don't know, a lot of that stuff today I don't feel that. Guys who are very excellent players, and that's not everybody, I mean this is kind of like some, like the wave is going away from the emotional side of music to its more intellectual side.

MW: Talk to us about, I caught a couple of your sets, which were just beautiful. Talk to us about your tone and some of your influences on the trumpet. You've already talked about Louis. But who did you listen to to help you formulate your tone and the way you play? Because the way you play is quite distinctive.

WB: Yes, well thank you. It's — my dad was a trumpet player, a really great trumpet player. He went to Juilliard Conservatory and he played in the, like I said earlier, he played with Cab Calloway, the Billy Eckstine band, the Walter Fats Pichon band, which is a band few people have heard of but that was a killer band. They played on the S.S. Dixie. They went up and down the Mississippi River. Man, Fats Pichon was a great writer, and he taught my dad a lot after my dad got out of Juilliard. I mean you know you learn a lot of application there, but when it comes to really doing it, you have to just do it. I mean you can take ice and all kinds of stuff and put it together and call it ice cream, but until it tastes like ice cream it's not it I don't think. But my dad really learned stuff with this Fats Pichon band. That was a great experience for him. But he was always a great, like, always went for projection out of his horn. And he would say, just like don't blow into your horn, blow through your horn. And that's one thing I try to maintain. That's one statement that stuck with me forever, blowing through the horn. Then I had a brother, a brother John, who is a great trumpet player. And you know, my dad quite naturally had all of the Louis Armstrong records, Roy Eldridge, you know, Charlie Shavers with Billie

Holiday and all of that stuff. So I grew up listening to really good music. I mean quite naturally, in the late '60s and early 70s when I started, I was a little teenager and I started first playing, and I played in all these rock bands you know. We were trying to play like Chicago and Blood Sweat and Tears type of stuff, which I thought was very well constructed music, still. But I had heard all of these Louis Armstrong doing like "I'm in the Market for You" with all of these beautiful, high notes, just coming out of the horn just like a butterfly, just chhhew. And you know quite naturally, with my brother being the next generation, Clifford Brown, Dizzy Gillespie, Kenny Dorham and all these kind of guys, you know, Donald Byrd and Howard McGhee and all of these, my brother was born of that generation. So I heard great music growing up. And so when I play, I try to emulate the best sounds that I've heard. And that's what I kind of attribute my tone to.

MW: Is there anything that you can give us a word on to get more music available to young people so — jazz is considered only three percent of the record market — to get more of this great music which is of American heritage on the menu?

WB: Well one thing I can say is I'm 40 years old now. No one wants to record anybody 40 years old. Once you've reached, you're 28, 29 years old, they take you off the market just about. You know? Even if you had a contract. So I mean I'm 40 now so all of my experience and abilities and whatever, I'm pretty much at the peak of what I've ever played in my life, right now. But all of the record contracts are going to people 17, 22 years old, and you know, young kids. And man this guy is going to be so-and-so. What about the guy that IS so-and-so? What about that?

MW: That is a thought.

WB: You know? So either you're 17, you know or 20; or you're 94 or something like this. And these are the people that are being recorded. And these — that is not the best era of a musician's career, when you're very, very young — I mean when I hear Wynton with the Art Blakey band, he was playing the living hell out of the trumpet. Whew. Man, that guy was playing some really great trumpet. So there are exceptions to this rule. But most of these contracts are going to these kids. And I think that's why people aren't buying the music. Most of the young people have like potential, but not necessarily that much to say right now. People will argue with me about that. It's okay, you know. You have your own thinking and everyone has theirs. But you know a friend of mine of a certain record company said he was too old to record for them. He was 29. 29. A great tenor player. He was too old. And it was a shock man. Too old and he's 29? I mean Charlie Parker was dead when he was 34, you know what I mean. So if they'd a said, hey Bird, you're 29 man, you're too old, just imagine all of the beautiful music we'd of been robbed of. Just imagine that. Oh, Billie Holiday you know? When she was 29 and she was doing all of

those beautiful things, "I Loves You Porgy" and all of those kinds. And this is what's happening. Marketing is like you know taking the art out of art.

MW: So the music and the marketing are two completely different camps.

WB: They're just two different things. And like I say, a lot of people will argue with me, but a lot of the students that I teach, like I said earlier, their main goal is to be famous. Well man, "I'm trying to get this contract." What are you going to do when you get the contract, son, you know? I'm sitting right here in the classroom with you and you know, when it comes to, you know, just some modal type of thing where they can do all kinds of jazzy, funny stuff on the instrument, they do quite well. But when it comes to playing inside of the chords, that's where they have the weakness. And I don't know, you have to know the rules before you can break the rules. And this is, I don't know, I think we're going to have to record more people with more experience. This is the way these younger guys are going to learn, you know? But I mean a lot of those young guys have great energy. I have a kid right now who's been around me ever since he was about six years old. His name is Nicholas Payton, you know of him?

MW: I've heard that name.

WB: He is a killer. But he grew up, he played in those New Orleans brass bands, and he, you know, he used to come around me a lot and then he went to a little school in New Orleans called NOCA, the New Orleans Center for the Creative Arts. And that brought him out. He learned his theory and this guy plays piano, he's a great drummer, plays bass, his dad is a bass player. He plays bass like unbelievable. And he's blowing the bell off of the trumpet. So there are exceptions to these things that I'm saying. But we're going to have to start recording some more mature people so the guys will get an idea of what a mature player plays like. You know how Dan was saying first he was trying to do all kinds of ripping and running and stuff like that? And eventually he learned, hey man, slow down, take your time. And this is what the younger players are going to learn from the more mature players. And I mean like when you hear Doc Cheatham man, you don't want to hear any more trumpet than that. He's swinging, he's just playing, I mean there is just so much there. And he's played like that for fifty, sixty, seventy years now. I mean Doc is 90, maybe 91 now. So I mean you know it's so important. Swing is so important. And swing does not mean fast. This is another misinterpretation we got going here. Swing does not mean fast.

MW: A real musician, a jazz musician can swing at any tempo.

WB: Any tempo. I mean Louis Armstrong could play one note and swing. I mean when you hear some of this stuff, Louis Armstrong singing, like with the Mills Brothers, just voices and a trumpet, and man did those guys swing. If you've never heard any of that stuff, get some of that. Unbelievable. There is one track on there that I mean comes to mind

immediately, “My Darling Nelly Gray.” And Louis sings a cadenza on the end that is unbelievable, it’s just so well paced, every zot, boop, bop and everything is just so well timed. It’s just, whooo. So we’re going to have to start really getting mature players to record. And you know we’ve got a lot of established players that are trying to play like — you know I claim I’m open minded so I’m going to play like the kids are playing, you know what I mean? [scats]. I don’t know, maybe that’s the wave, but I think we’re going to have to get back to melody and time.

MW: One thing someone said in terms of trying to show youngsters to respect people who’ve done more than they have is that little saying that says: a lot was done before you were born.

WB: That sounds like a great parting line. A lot was done before you were born.

MW: Yeah. And I know you’ve got to go. It’s been wonderful talking with you, and I think you’ve given some beautiful words of wisdom here.

WB: I hope so. It helps some guys to realize, hey, you know, maybe I’d better take a little bit more inventory and stop trying to be famous within the first two years of my playing.

MW: And the art is more precious than the trappings.

WB: Much more. Much, much more.

MW: Thank you. We’ve been filming here our Jazz Archive interview with Wendell Brunious.